Oakwood, Ohio
May 12, 2026

The Oakwood Citizen Budget Review Committee (BRC) met at 5:30 p.m. on Tuesday, May 12, 2026, in the council chambers at the city building, located at 30 Park Avenue.

The following people attended:

Budget Review Committee
In-person:
Jeanne Boozell
Erika Endsley
Curtis Farnsel
Ellen Fodge
Bill Frapwell, Vice Chair
John Gray
Ann Knerr-Smith
Amanda Malusky-Krauss
Kristina Marcus
Jim Milroy
Megan O'Leary
Bill Rieger
Tobias Schmitt
Jim Vaughn
Sarah Waechter
Raya Whalen

Oakwood City Council
In-person:
Mayor William Duncan
Vice Mayor Steve Byington
Council Member Leigh Turben
Council Member Healy Jackson
Council Member Sam Dorf

City Staff
In-person:
City Manager Katie Smiddy
Public Safety Director Alan Hill
Law Director Rob Jacques
Public Works Director Doug Spitler
Assistant Public Works Director/City Engineer Chris Kuzma
Human Resources Director Sangita Anand
Finance Director Maralee Leonard
Code Enforcement Officer Sarah Valentin
Clerk of Council Lori Stacel

Mayor Bill Duncan opened the meeting with a welcome. He introduced the new members of the committee and then asked the committee members to give their self-introductions. He asked if there were any suggested edits to the minutes of the November 18, 2025, meeting. There being no edits, Mayor Duncan asked for a motion to approve the minutes. Motion to approve by Jim Vaughn; second by Raya Whalen. Upon viva voce vote, the motion passed, and the minutes were approved.

OPENING COMMENTS/CAPITAL IMPROVEMENTS

Mayor Duncan invited Finance Director Maralee Leonard to make opening comments and present the financial data.

Ms. Leonard presented an overview of the Finance Department's modernization initiatives, highlighting the City's transition from paper-based processes to more efficient, technology-driven systems.

Key initiatives include:

- Expansion of the employee self-service portal
- Digitization of accounts payable processing
- Implementation of the CityTax system for electronic filing and payments
- Transition to a cloud-based Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) system
- Development of a digital interactive budget book
- Implementation of a budget analytics module to enhance forecasting and reporting capabilities

Ms. Leonard noted that these initiatives are designed to improve efficiency, accuracy, internal controls, transparency, and staff development. Success will be measured through reduced processing times, improved audit outcomes, faster reporting, increased staff engagement, and expanded public access to financial information.

PUBLIC SAFETY CAPITAL IMPROVEMENTS

Chief Hill provided an update on capital improvements within the Public Safety Department.

He reported that the most significant upcoming investment is the purchase of a new fire engine, expected for delivery in March or April 2027, at an estimated total cost of $960,000, including equipment and portable radios.

Chief Hill also reported receipt of approximately $515,000 in forfeiture funds related to a forgery case. These funds will be used for capital needs including:

- Dispatch console upgrades
- Replacement of portable radios
- Upgrades to in-car body cameras
- Acquisition of a second electric vehicle
- Replacement of a detective vehicle

An additional forfeiture is anticipated and will be allocated toward firearm replacements.

Mr. Dorf inquired about the long-term viability of the dispatch console. Chief Hill stated it is expected to remain in service until approximately 2038–2040.

Mr. Schmitt asked about disposition of the existing fire truck. Chief Hill stated it will be sold.

Ms. Boozell asked about funding for the second electric vehicle. Chief Hill noted that forfeiture funds will cover the cost, reducing reliance on General Fund dollars, and that fuel savings may offset costs over time.

2025 YEAR-END FINANCIAL RECAP

Ms. Leonard provided the 2025 year-end revenue recap as follows:

- Income tax (net of refunds): $11.3 million
- Property tax: $3.1 million
- Enterprise revenues: $5.0 million
- Refuse revenues: $1.6 million
- Other revenues: $3.7 million

Beginning and ending fund balances were also reviewed.

2026 FINANCIAL UPDATE THROUGH APRIL

Ms. Leonard presented a five-year history of General Fund receipts, noting major revenue sources including income tax, property tax, and refuse, sewer, stormwater.

Mr. Vaughn asked about encumbrances; Ms. Leonard confirmed most relate to capital projects.

Mrs. Fodge asked about income tax comparisons; Ms. Leonard reported collections are slightly lower than last year due to timing of lockbox receipts (approximately 40% collected vs. 45% last year).

Mr. Vaughn suggested separating capital expenditures from encumbrances in future reporting formats. Ms. Leonard will update the formatting accordingly moving forward.

Mr. Milroy asked about fund balance guidelines. Ms. Leonard stated that targets exist but require professional judgment in application.

Mrs. Malusky-Krauss asked about the approval process for financial transactions. Ms. Leonard explained that the previous process was paper-based, but the updated system now includes built-in workflow queues requiring multiple levels of approval, including department heads, the Finance Director, and Accounts Payable.

2026 INFRASTRUCTURE PROJECTS

Ms. Leonard presented planned infrastructure projects scheduled for summer through early fall 2026:

- Sidewalk, Curb, and Driveway Apron Program (Zones 2 and 3): $500,000
- Asphalt Program (currently out for bid): $500,000
- Concrete Street program (Shafor Boulevard between East Thruston Boulevard and Irving Avenue): $400,000

In response to a question from Mrs. Ann Knerr-Smith regarding responsibility for costs associated with the Sidewalk, Curb, and Driveway Apron Program, Mr. Kuzma explained that the City covers the majority of project expenses, while property owners are responsible for the cost of sidewalk improvements along the frontage of their property.

Mr. Dorf asked about the rate of increasing costs and how the City plans for future expenses. Mr. Kuzma stated that the City receives annual projections to help anticipate cost increases and has adjusted program zones in recent years to better manage project scope and costs.

CITY INITIATIVES

Mrs. Smiddy provided updates on several initiatives:

- Organizational Assessment: A consultant-led assessment recommended consolidation of Leisure Services functions into Public Works and identified operational efficiencies.

- Water System Review: The City has engaged consultants to evaluate system conditions in response to new Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) regulations and to develop a long-term plan.
- Park Master Plan: A $6.5 million grant application has been submitted for Phase I improvements at Shafor and Orchardly Parks. The plan is being developed with Bayer Becker and remains in early stages.
- Old River Soccer Fields: The City is conducting a study of field conditions to guide long-term improvements. The goal is to ensure durable, sustainable investments in partnership with Oakwood United Soccer Club.

Mr. Rieger commented on the City's water system study, asking if infrastructure within private residences is included in the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) regulations. Mrs. Smiddy clarified that under current Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) regulations related to lead service line replacement, responsibility extends from the curb stop to the home, while any plumbing within the home remains the responsibility of the property owner and is not part of the regulations.

PROPERTY TAX

Mrs. Smiddy provided an update regarding the proposed elimination of property taxes.

She shared that the required number of signatures was not obtained to place the issue on the ballot; however, she anticipates the matter will be revisited. She noted that the City, local schools, and the library are working collaboratively to develop consistent messaging to inform the public about the potential impacts on services and staffing.

In response to a question regarding potential actions if such a measure were to pass, Mrs. Smiddy stated that many municipalities would likely consider increasing income tax rates, as there is currently no state plan to replace lost funding. She added that reductions in programs and services would also need to be considered.

Mr. Schmitt asked how Oakwood's income tax rate compares with other communities. Mrs. Smiddy reported that Oakwood's current rate is 2.5 percent and noted that many communities are increasing their rates.

Mrs. Whalen asked about the City's communication strategies. Mrs. Smiddy shared that information will be shared using multiple platforms, including social media, the Oakwood Register, City website, school communications to parents, and other available channels. She added that Miami Valley Technology and Communications Group (MVTCG) may assist with video production to help convey key messages.

Mrs. Fodge asked whether income tax revenues generated locally are returned to the city through the State. Ms. Leonard clarified that, in contrast, property tax levies, when approved or renewed, are returned 100 percent to the City.

The Mayor noted that, even if broader efforts to eliminate property taxes were pursued, such initiatives could reappear through future petition efforts and are not expected to go away. He added that the General Assembly is actively exploring various approaches to reduce property tax burdens for residents.

PROPERTY TAX LEVY RENEWAL

Ms. Leonard provided the following information regarding the 2.72-mill property tax renewal:

- First approved: May 1991
- Annual revenue: approximately $479,000
- Estimated cost: $35.36 per $100,000 of valuation
- Current effective rate: 1.010210 mills
- Term: five years
- Scheduled ballot: November 3, 2026

FUTURE CAPITAL EXPENSES

The following future capital needs were reviewed:

- Computer equipment: $50,000
- Traffic signal replacements (2027–2033): $1.2 million annually
- Concrete street program: $250,000 annually
- Asphalt street program: $550,000 annually
- Sidewalk, curb, and apron program: $720,000 annually

Water and sewer infrastructure needs were also discussed, along with the City's approach to financing projects. Staff noted that all available funding resources are being evaluated.

Mr. Dorf commented that capital investments can result in long-term cost savings.

ADDITIONAL DISCUSSION ITEMS

Mr. Gray inquired about the property at 1313 Far Hills Avenue, where a house was previously demolished. The Mayor responded that the lot has been sold and is planned for a single-family home.

An update was also provided regarding Kettering Health Network, noting that representatives met with the City approximately three weeks ago and indicated a decision would be made by the end of the year regarding their plans. Ms. Malusky-Krauss asked about next steps if Kettering Health Network elects not to proceed, noting that a developer has not yet made a final commitment.

ADJOURNMENT

There being no further business, at 6:45 p.m. Mayor Duncan thanked the committee members for their service, and the meeting was adjourned.

Vice Chairman